

Chapter 7

Creative Tension of Sense and the Whole Approach to Knowledge and Practice



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7.1 Introduction

Epistemology has an important role to play in discussion about the “new” Geopolitics of Knowledge. One reason is that the processes of construction and transmission of knowledge in the West are important for understanding both the problems of today’s societies and the proposals for change. Within this Western model, the university has played a central role as one of the certifiers of valid and “true” knowledge. The debate about epistemology or epistemologies in a “new” Geopolitics of Knowledge can also contribute to epistemological debate taking place outside the specific area of the theory of science. This is important for the inclusion of traditions and communities that historically have not had their knowledge recognised, or whose knowledge traditions have been destroyed in the different colonization processes and their derivatives. Reflection is important within the “new” Geopolitics of Knowledge because it can build a dialogue between different epistemologies in different contexts. Certainly, one of the challenges is still to relativize the rigid limits that separate epistemology, ontology, and hermeneutics.

This discussion of a “new” Geopolitics of Knowledge is important not only for those countries that received knowledge according to the colonial model, but also for those colonizers that imposed it (Barreto & Sirvent, 2019). There is a strong criticism of the epistemologies that have sustained and continue to sustain the project of the development and expansion of Europe and the North Atlantic (Mignolo, 2000, 2011). This debate reveals how this project was built on the premise that there was always a “superior” who, directly or indirectly, should dominate the “inferior”. The consequence was that knowledge located in European and North Atlantic

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thought took universal forms through cultural, political, intellectual, religious, industrial, economic, and technological expansion (Quijano, 2000).

In this context, the university has become one of the instruments for the institutionalization of this knowledge project, which separates the “small” from the “big” and the center from the periphery. Including epistemology in this discussion is crucial because, as several authors have shown, modernity needs to be thought from a paradigm other than the one that generated it (Santos, 2014). The process of building new knowledge paradigms should include epistemologies that were left out (Dussel, 2002, 2018). Eurocentric and American epistemologies shape economics, philosophy, theology, sociology, museology, education, psychology, and politics in a hegemonic way, thus excluding what is thought of as other. But the exclusion also happened on the inside, as is visible in the constant conflicts that result from the hegemonic model of transmission, production, and accessibility, which shows that exclusion also occurs in the tension between center and periphery within Europe and the United States. Several authors have sought to debate this issue and to offer alternatives (e.g. Boatcă, 2010; Jones, 2019). However, it can be said that there is a great complexity in translating such important reflections into practical projects. Currently, the production, validation, and transmission of knowledge is still highly dependent on the economic strength of a country’s or region’s center of power.

The theory of the “creative tension of sense” presented in this chapter was developed in my research as a way of mapping the “tensions of sense” that exist in all areas of knowledge and in society today. This tension of sense, it is argued, has as its central roots in the birth of the “new” world within the “old” world. As a result, all segments of society are impacted by these tensions brought about by change (referred to as tensions of change). The capacity to act in today’s conditions of tension relates to the existence, or even the disappearance, of institutions and forms of knowledge.

The theory of the creative tension of sense shows the search to make sense of life within the tensions of paradigms. The search for sense is experienced differently in the tensions of change within Europe, North America, Latin America, Asia, and elsewhere. The theory of creative sense tension offers an epistemology that addresses tensions in the context where they arise.

A “new” Geopolitics of Knowledge, from this perspective, would necessarily be related to epistemological issues, which would foster a rethinking of the nature, production, and dissemination of knowledge at a global level (Mignolo, 2003). The various challenges of today’s societies should also become challenges of the new Geopolitics of Knowledge. Western societies have several old demands within new realities, among them, technologies, digital transformation, scarcity of work, the role of social networks, artificial intelligence, climate change, sustainability, and the limits of growth, or concept of “degrowth” (Berry, 1999). There are also further tensions caused by the current Covid-19 pandemic, which has further revealed the profound weaknesses of the design of societies in various parts of the world.

What epistemologies can help to build the role of the “new” Geopolitics of Knowledge in this context of tensions? (Reiter, 2018) How can the “new” Geopolitics of Knowledge contribute to the discussion of the presence of different

epistemologies in higher education within the perspective of tensions? Perhaps, the challenge is not just to deconstruct, but above all to build new paths on the edge of the abyss. This is the tension presented by the birth of the new world within the old world.

The tension of the new within the old generates a search for sense. This also causes a tension in the being. It is the tension between the “weak self” and the “strong self”. It is the epistemological movement that takes place in paradigm transitions. For this reason, the theory of the creative tension of sense aims at the identification of tensions of sense, thus making possible the birth of the “new”. The starting point is not a value judgment, even if it is always present. Rather, the starting point of the theory of the creative tension of sense is the perception and description of tensions in the context in which the search for the sense of life takes place because of the changes experienced. This process brings theory and practice closer together in the local context. This tension questions the validity of the new and the permanence of the old as a sense of existence—this is the epistemological stance of tension theory. The university, as one of the agents of the construction and systematization of (theories of) knowledge, also experiences this tension. For this reason, the university can be both the cause of the problem and one of the solutions by including new theories of knowledge based on historically silenced epistemologies.

The epistemology of the theory of the creative tension of sense always thinks theory and practice together. For this reason, a practical dimension of the theory of the creative tension of sense is central. The *Ganz-Methode*, or Whole approach to tension, was developed in my work with the WTS Coaching program. The WTS Coaching methodology was developed in the context of tension experiences used in the cases of individual development, local development through ecomuseums and the theater, business development, educational development through schools, institutional development, and sustainable development. These case studies took place in the city of Rio de Janeiro (Brazil) from 2013 to 2020. But the tension of sense is also within the development projects and Coaching models. They were created within the hegemonological epistemology that is the cause, for example, of climate change on the planet and the tense relationship between metropolis and periphery. The WTS Coaching program is an attempt to create the practices of the “new” world in tension with the “old” world. Therefore, this program is the questioning of this hegemonic epistemology through the tension of models and the Whole-Transdisciplinary Sustainability, WTS. This questioning takes place in theory and in practice (Toit & Sim, 2010).

This chapter aims to present the theory of the creative tension of sense and how it can offer an epistemological contribution to rethink higher education in the content of the tension of the birth of the “new” world within the “old”. The *first* part briefly presents a discussion of epistemology in the “new” Geopolitics of Knowledge and the tension in trying to conceptualize the limits of modernity. The *second* part deliberates on the tension between an ancient paradigm that has not yet died and the new one that has not yet been fully born. The *third* part presents the practical translation of the theory discussed here in the two steps of the *Ganz-Methode* in the

context of tensions. The first step is about the process of sustaining tensions in order to build the whole approach in motion. The whole is always in tension. The second step of the *Ganz-Methode* refers to how the whole approach to tensions leads to the discovery of *life power* and the sense of life values. The *fourth* and last part of the chapter suggests how it is possible to develop a practical coaching program built from the epistemology of tension and the *Ganz-Methode*. This program can be applied in universities and institutions that seek to face the tensions of the birth of the new world within the old world.

The following section discusses the tensions involved in conceptualizing the limits of modernity.

7.2 Tensions in Conceptualizing the Limits of Modernity

There is a plurality of conceptualizations of the limits of modernity, in several disciplinary fields. Some accounts have been developed in countries that have historically received the knowledge produced in Europe and the United States. The limits of modernity directly imply the tension and struggle of new epistemologies seeking academic validity (Santos, 2014). Many thinkers have constructed different concepts to understand the great changes in contemporary society (see for instance: Leff, 2014; Morin, 2014; Dussel, 2018). However, the issues raised demonstrate the limits of modernity. Their approach to the paradigm of society opens new possibilities to see the discontinuities between modernity and postmodernity (Delanty, 2000).

The exhaustion of the great models of knowledge of modernity is evident in the economy, in the concept of development, and in many other areas of society. The problem is not only in the search for meaning in peripheral countries seeking to build their own knowledge, but also within the countries that produced this knowledge and imposed it through processes of colonization. The tension of sense is implicitly and explicitly present in the discussion about the limits of modernity. Leff (2014, p. 88f.), for example, shows that the environmental crisis has revealed the limits of modernity's rationality:

Beyond the epistemological controversies about the truth and objectivity of knowledge; beyond the problem of real representation through theory and Science the knowledge has turned against the world; it has interfered and dislocated it. Before emerging as a problem of knowledge in the field of epistemology, this crisis of modern rationality manifested itself in the sensitivity of poetry and philosophical thought. Yet, the critique of Enlightened reason and modernity which had been initiated by the critique of metaphysics (Nietzsche, Heidegger), critical rationalism (Adorno, Horkheimer, Marcuse), structuralist thought (Althusser, Foucault, Lacan), and by the philosophy of postmodernism (Levinas, Deleuze, Guattari, Derrida), was not enough to convey the radicalism of the limits-law of nature against the ravings of economic rationality. This had to be shown in the reality of nature, outside the symbolic order, to do justice to reason. The environmental crisis erupts at a time when the rationality of modernity translates into an anti-natura reason. This is not a functional or operative crisis of the prevailing economic rationality, but rather one of its foundations and ways of knowing the world. Environmental rationality thus emerges out of the

questioning of the economization of the world, out of the overflow of the reifying rationality of modernity, out of the excesses of objectivist and utilitarian thought.

Leff (2014) continues to show the intrinsic relationship between environmental crisis and knowledge produced in modernity:

The environmental crisis is a product of knowledge – be it true or false – about the real, about matter, about the world. It is a crisis of the ways of comprehending the world, since mankind makes its appearance as an animal inhabited by language which makes human history split from natural history, makes it a history of meaning and of the meaning assigned by the words to things, generating power strategies in theory and in knowledge that have disrupted the real to forge the modern world- system. (ibid., p. 89)

Although these critiques are important, I focus on presenting the tension between the new world growing within the old world. These new forms give sense to life, and provoke tensions both inside and outside the paradigm of modern rationality. This is the concept of the tension society.

An example of this tension may be the intense debate that seeks to conceptualize the present era. Several authors seek to identify whether we are in the crisis of modernity, the end of modernity, or postmodernity (Delanty, 2000). A conceptual definition that excludes other definitions is not enough to understand the major changes that impact knowledge, however. A possible approach is to analyze the new and old models of society together. These tension models are present in fields of academic knowledge, and in society more generally, as a search for sense. It is already possible to perceive elements of the creative tension of sense.

The environmental crisis reveals the tension of meaning in the project of society and the development of the hegemonic epistemology of modernity. The need to build Whole Sustainability ¹ shows the exhaustion of this epistemic model (Delambre, 2014). There is a need to recognize and value other epistemologies in the world that propose an entire relationship of affective listening and listening in tension with nature and interpersonal relationships.

An example of this tension of sense occurs in the relationship between the residents of the favelas in Rio de Janeiro and the residents of the city. In the favela of Rocinha, the theater group “Bando Cultural Favelados da Rocinha” develops theater plays based on their pain. They tell their stories of the violence suffered by the

¹Whole Sustainability is the application of Tension theory to the science and practice of sustainability. The Whole Sustainability concept questions the sustainability subject to the epistemology of the hegemonic development models. It is whole because it uses the Ganz-Method to foster the creation of sustainable projects for the “new” world. This sustainability is whole because it needs to include everything that represents the life power of the local community and, at the same time, the internal and external threats to this life power. Entire sustainability is the application of stress theory to the science and practice of sustainability. The entire sustainability concept questions the sustainability subject to the epistemology of the hegemonic development model. It is whole because it uses the ganz method to foster the creation of sustainable projects for the “new” world. This sustainability is integral because it needs to include everything that represents the life power of the local community and, at the same time, the internal and external threats to this life power. And the life power is everything that the local community has and it interprets as the sense of existence and continuity between past, present and future.

favela residents in the city. The director, Richard Castelo Branco, developed his own method (*EspectAtoR*) informed by an epistemology of resistance. This epistemology is in tension with the city's official knowledge models (Branco, 2020). This knowledge of the favela is not used by the centers of knowledge power, nor is it transformed into economic capital in the country. The desire to see knowledge of the favela being used for the country's development was the dream of Camilla de Hollanda Amado, who was an important Brazilian actress and theater director. Camilla Amado helped give visibility to this cultural group through the project "Bora Bora em Bando" that we founded together. She died on June 6, 2021, aged 82.

For example, work in social museology (Moutinho, 2007) and ecomuseology in Brazil has sought for some years to include the epistemologies of favela museums, community museums, and ecomuseums in official environments. In this work, the protagonists are the residents themselves. They tell their stories, preserve their memories, and resist attempts by the hegemonic system to erase their stories (Chagas, 2001). Orality is the hallmark of knowledge production and transmission of wisdom in the great traditions in Africa Latin America, and many other parts of the world. The value of oral traditions and memory also reveals the tension of sense with the epistemology of the closed rationality of modernity, as visible in the understanding of history developed by the 'École des Annales', founded by Marc Bloch and Lucien Febvre (cf. Burke, 2002).

The tension of sense takes place within the paradigm of modernity. This tension is no longer restricted only to the analysis of how hegemonic centers nullify the knowledge of the peripheries. This is an important step in the process; however, the exhaustion of this paradigm reveals the tension of sense in both the hegemonic centers of power and in the peripheries. In many cases, there is a great seduction in the periphery by the epistemic paradigm of hegemony. For this reason, the epistemology of the theory of tension is the attempt to be an alternative to produce "new" knowledge that goes beyond the conceptualizations of the paradigms of modernity and postmodernity. There is a difficulty in defining what modernity and postmodernity are. It is not clear whether we are in hypermodernity (Lipovetsky & Charles, 2005), liquid modernity (Bauman, 2012), or second or reflexive modernity (Beck, 2006). Similar attempts to define modernity and postmodernity take place in philosophy: "weak thought" (Vattimo & Rovatti, 2012), "burnout society" (Han, 2015), and risk society (Beck, 2006). The tension is implicit in these definitions of modernity and postmodernity. The verification of the limits of today's society is clear. The theory of the creative tension of sense proposes a transition from theoretical reflection to practice within a tense society where tensions have increased exponentially. Therefore, the epistemology of tension is built on the permanent interrelationship between theory and practice. The tensions show continuity in the discontinuity. This is the birth of the "new" world within the "old" world. The tension of sense is a mark of the "new" world, the topic discussed in the next section

7.3 The Tension Derived from the Birth of the New World Within the Old World

It is possible to observe the tension of sense as a function of the birth of the new within the old world. It is also important to state that the terms old, conventional, traditional, new, and current are insufficient to explain the transitions in society. These terms are themselves subject to rapid change. New and old can be relative in models of tension in all segments of society. Therefore, the epistemology in which theory and practice are thought together is derived from concrete situations. What criteria will be used to choose between the new and the old?

The new and the old are always connected by what made sense yesterday and no longer makes sense today. Even the definition of what is new and old must be understood from within the tension between the two. It is important to observe the established, novel, and germinating senses of life within local communities. What gave sense in the past but no longer does now? What is born but not fully developed? These situations are present in tense relationships throughout various spheres of society, especially in the daily life of the local community. These include economic models, development projects, public policies, educational models, and others (Beck, 2006). The paradigm is tension of sense.

The contribution of the creative tension of sense to a new Geopolitics of Knowledge is not restricted to a discussion of the classical theory of knowledge alone: it includes a Whole Approach to reality. This approach considers the constant relationship between theory and practice where there are sense tensions. Therefore, it is not about any tension, but the tension of sense.

The relations of sense between old models and new models in various areas are fundamental conditions for the nature of this epistemology. That is why I am not referring to any specific tension, but to the sense of existence of an individual, a group, a people, an organization, a company, a public policy, an urbanization project, a city, a model of development, a program of sustainability, a body of knowledge, or a theory. This tension of sense occurs in the tense relationship between the birth of the new world within a context of tense-pluralistic epistemologies in the world: the crisis of the rationality of modernity, rapid changes, whole sustainability challenges, artificial intelligence, etc. raise questions about what is the sense of life, what is the human, and so on. Tension of sense between the “weak self ” and the “strong self ”. The tension is ancient, but it is also new. For this reason, the creative tension of sense is a theory of knowledge that is born from concrete situations where the impact of the tension of the “new” and “ancient” provokes the sense experience. These changes directly provoke the question of the sense of life itself.

This search for sense exists in the tension that occurs in traditional institutions, in changes in society, and between the fragile frontiers of areas of knowledge. At this point, it is important to emphasize that the whole tension approach shows the tense relationship between the new knowledge that emerges in society and the formal knowledge of institutions. The response time to the search for sense in society is very fast and increasing exponentially. So even the way you feel about time is tense.

The tense relationship between the new and the old in society generates attempts to respond to the sense of existence. With this, it is possible to reflect on knowledge both in terms of the nature of knowledge and the productions of sense in the daily life of the local community. In this field, the frontiers of the areas of knowledge are fragile and subliminal. Here, too, there is the tension with the conventional models of knowledge production. The construction of knowledge today follows other logics because the main issue is the need for sense in the face of rapidly changing situations. Therefore, in this epistemology, the approach to making sense of reality is tense, whole, in a movement of exponential change, and constant. The crises of institutions arises in this context (Bauman, 2012). Universities are in this crisis. The tension in knowledge is also the tension in knowledge models in higher education.

The tension is whole. This same tension also occurs in the local community. It is the tension of sense between the local community and wider society. Tensions currently impact the main areas of local community life that relate to the sense of being in everyday relationships. Above all the tension is present in the internal relations of change with the implementation of external and global projects. The tension intensifies when these projects disregard the protagonism of the local community, the active participation of its representatives, the collective memory, the history of the local community, and decreases jobs. The tension of a specific area can reach the whole community and even beyond. In some cases, it is impossible to predict the consequences of this tension because of the rapid changes and other factors of that networked society. The tension of the birth of the “new” world within the “old” world impacts companies, the economy, and the labor market. In these contexts, the time for reflection on the situation is extremely short, especially because the changes are rapid. Without specific methods for making decisions within tensions, it is possible that we will face many challenges and major conflicts today. These conflicts endanger the survival of the local community and the external community in this tense society. In this context, the Ganz-Methode provides the practical dimension of tension theory. Theory and practice are inseparable in the epistemology of the theory of the creative tension of sense. The Ganz-methode is the whole dimension of the Tension Theory. It makes it possible to make whole decisions considering tensions. Whole or Ganz is the identification and articulation of tensions together. Therefore, the *whole* is the whole approach to reality that is always changing. Whole here is not synonymous with holistic.

7.4 The Ganz-Methode 1: Sustaining Tension to Build the Whole Approach in Motion

In the Ganz-Methode, the tension does not need to be resolved or dissolved in the first attempt. There are steps that need to be followed. The tension needs to be sustained. Sustaining the tension of sense allows time for internal change within a local

community. This is necessary because the tension is not only external; there is also a period of internal change within the individual. Therefore, the tension takes place in a dimension of sense of existence. With this, other questions concerning the sense of life should be considered in the transition process without excluding the old because of the new.

At this stage, it is necessary to have a whole observation of the tensions that refer to the sense of existence. This whole approach to all the tensions involved in the process is the *Ganz-Methode*. Therefore, in the epistemology of tension, there is no separation between ontology, hermeneutics, and epistemology itself. There is not even a language ready to capture the totality of the whole approach to tensions. The whole approach of the *Ganz-Methode* does indeed open the possibility for the “mystery”, the “surprise”, the “fascination”, the “vulnerable” and the “uncontrollable” of the “new” to happen. The tension of sense is the possibility of the “new” being born within the “old”. The whole approach is the space to accommodate tensions with the possibility that all dimensions of life have the value of existence and sense. Here it is not necessary to dwell on the philosophical questions about existence that drives the transition, but rather on the question about the whole sense of coexistence. Therefore, the question is present even when there is silence. The starting point is not the answer, it is the silence that exists in the strained relationship of the birth of the “new” within “old”.

Therefore, in the whole approach of *Ganz-Methode*, the new needs the old for its existence with whole sense. It is necessary to develop a model of education that can sustain tension: models of policies, models of growth, models of economy, models of spirituality, models of research, models of coaching, models of individual and human development. Tension will be a condition through which to understand and engage in questions raised by society’s exponential rate of change, e.g. digital experience, and to make decisions with whole approaches. This is the possibility to make decisions within the exponential tensions of change in a tense society.

7.5 The Ganz-Methode 2: Life Power and Values of Sense of Life in the Local Community and in the Global Context

Even if the new gains autonomy and currency, this autonomy will always be in a tense relationship with the old or ancient. Even if the old remains, it will always remain in tension with the new. For this reason, the creative tension of sense is above all an epistemology of tense interpretation and of whole actions within the age of exponential change: crises of modernity’s closed rationality, the protagonism of “new” epistemologies around the world, and, profound changes of sense that affect all areas of society. The new reinforces the limits of the ancient, but the ancient confirms the limits of the new in the *Ganz-Methode*. The methodology for sustaining the tensions is very important for describing the life power within the

relationship between new and old. Life power refers to the practice of searching for the sense of life that appears in the whole approach to tensions. The tense society is at the limit of life sense and yet we do not have the security to solve the problems and exponential tensions in several areas. This is demonstrated in the current context of the Covid-19 pandemic.

At this stage of the whole approach of the *Ganz-Methode*, it is vital that interim rules and regulations are built. They protect and promote the sustainability of the values of life in tension, the protagonism of the local community, the dignity of the person, the preservation of biodiversity, the development of local memory, the participation in decision-making in society, the dignity of groups that have been excluded, the spiritualities, orality, art, and the different forms of sense of life and life power.

However, there is also a sense tension in the values of life at the birth of the new world within the old. The values of life are also in a tense relationship between the community and the wider global context. The whole approach to tensions shows the tension within the values for life. This method can also reveal values for death, that is, the extermination of the other simply by the fact of being another. Therefore, the whole approach makes it possible to expose the values underpinning tense relationships. Thus, it becomes possible to construct criteria, norms, regulations, mediations, and actions of whole impact for the preservation of the life and the whole health in the local community. This is the life power and whole sustainability in tension.

The methodology of “sustaining the tensions” opens the ethical discussion within the tension between the birth of the new world within the old: should the new or old have priority in tense situations? This means that the new can be more important in one context, but in another the old one is more plausible. However, in any case, it is crucial to make decisions within the tension of both the local and global context. The contexts of tensions are rapid changes, environmental crisis, epistemological diversity, degrowth, and digitisation.

However, it is necessary to separate the tensions in the whole approach in order to make decisions. The whole approach of tensions is always adapting to the movement of rapid changes and tense epistemologies around the world: this is the *era of exponential tensions*. However, it is important to separate some areas to show how the creative tension of sense occurs in different segments in society. The academic context, for example, lives this tension in reality: the tension between academic knowledge and non-formal knowledge.

In many cases, the university is unable to keep up with the speed of the transition. The entry of young people into the digital economy is one example. The concept of storytelling marketing (Aguiari, 2021) is an example of this tension with conventional models. There is a creative tension of sense between the old and the new within the disciplines. This opens a tension to define the nature of the discipline. The dialogue with other, related disciplines gives rise to proposals that interfere with the definition and the central contents of the discipline. This generates the sense tension between the new and the conventional (Burke, 2002).

There is also a creative tension of sense in the curricula of particular disciplines or fields. Everyday it is possible to perceive the emergence of new areas to cover in the curriculum. Tension occurs because the traditional of the discipline may lose space. This tension impacts the design of the course and it causes tension in the power relations of the academic universe. Therefore, the sense tension exists within the higher education institutions. The tensions in the disciplines and the design of the course cause a tension in the nature of the knowledge of the faculty itself.

The whole approach to society reveals the tension between global interests and rights in the local community. This impacts other areas of society. In several parts of the world, it is possible to perceive the tension of sense between the participation of the residents and the defense of the rights of the local community and global interests. This tension will be reflected in the concept of development being used and the practical results of such development. It is the tension between people's rights in the local community and global interests (Benadiba & Plotinsky, 2005).

The institutions are related to the community and the development model will impact the community. Tension between the development model focused on fossil fuels and the renewable energy model impacts on the sense of life of the local and external community. In that case, global warming places a tension on the sense of life for society. It is the tension between two development projects that has implications for all areas of society (Rahmstorf & Schellnhuber, 2012).

The whole approach to the society in tension shows that the tension of sense is also present in the relationship models, for instance the tension between the project of life focused on interpersonal relationships and the virtual relations of social networks. The exponential tensions presented by social networks and the digital-technological era impact several concepts related to the sense of life, among them presence, absence, distance, solitude, company, real, virtual, truth, lie, anguish, exchange, participation, engagement, information, knowledge, learning, performance, individual and collective development, fatigue, good, evil, anxiety, happiness, death, and life. This leads to the search again for the sense of being alive. It is the "Whole Crossing" in the tension of change inside the tension between the "weak self" and the "strong self".

This is the tension brought about by the impact of social networks on the organization of societies and people's lives. (Castells, 2012). There is a tension of sense between the epistemology of human development, human sciences, and sustainable health. What is a whole life today and the concept of "life power" (*Die Lebenskraft*) of each person in the exponential tension and tension of sense? At this point, the tension theory of sense is a new theory of human development, individual and collective, based on the tension of sense, the exponential tension, and the whole approach to life and society.

The tension of the birth of the new world within the old world impacts the way in which human beings find the sense for their existence. Therefore, the whole approach to tensions leads to the discovery of personal life power, and the life power of the organization, the company, the university, and the city. Life power is the practical repositioning of decisions to develop a whole impact for life. Before being a theoretical reflection on the sense of life, life power (*Lebenskraft*) is the experience

that arises from the tension between the new and the old. This is concept of whole life intersecting with tension theory.

But there is also tension between old information vehicles and social media vehicles. The possibility of narrating the same fact through various media opens up a tension of sense in society and in organizations. This tension is greater in institutions that historically possessed the power over information and its transmission. The tension of sense lies in the power of information but also in the concept of truth. But the tense society also holds the tension between traditional knowledge production authorities and social media authorities. Today, people who have no formal credibility can become authorities on various subjects through social media. These people are influential. Some are called “influencers”, with thousands of followers, who offer a kind of knowledge that has not been produced in formal environments. So, there is a tension of sense in knowledge, in authorities, and in the definition in truth and what is important for the preparation of students for participation in society.

Another central point of sense tension is the tension between the use of artificial intelligence, technologies, and the digital economy, and the needs of the human being. There is an increasing tension of sense in all the segments in which human protagonism was previously the most important. In the past, companies needed people to make their businesses successful. But now there is a tension of sense existence. In the labor market, for example, there is the tension of sense between companies with workers and companies without workers. It is the tension of precarious work. The use of artificial intelligence and digital technologies question the need for human participation in different areas of society. How should companies and society act within this tension? How can we make an economy dominated by artificial intelligence, digital technology, the internet, and social media work for all people? (Unger, 2019)

Tension between the economy with labor and the economy without employers, productivity, and with more applications and “rentism” is the great tension in capitalism, or the exponential tension in capitalism. When the advancement of the economy no longer needs the worker for its existence, it opens a tension in the project of society in Western capitalism. The tension increases because it can become more profitable for the CEO of the company to save money rather spend it on the company or the development of society. The impact of changes in the economy causes the tension of a sense of existence in other areas and the purpose of the economy in a capitalist society. It is the great tension within capitalism, as illustrated by the debate about the de-growth (D’Alisa et al., 2015; Romano, 2019). Therefore, a whole approach to tensions is important to make decisions by always linking theory and practice.

7.6 *Ganz-Methode* and the Whole Tension Approach: WTS Coaching

Ganz-Methode is the whole approach to tensions in the context of new epistemologies and rapid changes. This whole approach to tension is taken in the specific context where the tension exists but also in relation to the external context of tension. In *Ganz-Methode*, there is a constant relationship between the tensions that happen on the global scale and those that happen at the local level. By detecting the elements of the new and the old that form the tension, it becomes essential to describe the models and present them so that it is possible to visualize the new and the old together. Next, it is important to realize the relationship between this tension in the specific context and the tensions on the same subject in wider, global environments. Choosing the priority of the new over the old or the old over the new depends on the interpretation of the scenario's impact. An impact is presumed, but its consequences must be observed in both the local and global environment.

The whole approach in *Ganz-Methode* makes it possible to make choices within fast changes and exponential tensions. With *Ganz-Methode*, it is possible to build new models, develop practical projects, and constantly measure the impacts of change and exponential tensions. These projects always unite theory and practice and maintain the tension. Hence, the philosophical concept shows that the whole is always in the movement of change. Thus, the philosophical premise underlying the *Ganz-Methode* is the tense relationship between models within tense epistemologies, rapid change, and exponential tensions. These changes are analyzed in the specific context of tension and in relation to the wider context. Therefore, in the whole approach in *Ganz-Methode*, practical actions respond to the sense of existence. These actions prioritize the values of life and the whole sustainability concept. Hence, the creative tension of sense depends on the whole *Ganz-Methode* approach, and the whole approach depends on the creative tension of sense. In the context of exponential tension, very little is known about the future. Everything is temporary and tense.

All areas of sense tension are connected internally and externally. Decisions in the local context impact the global context and vice versa. With *Ganz-Methode*, it is possible to have a greater sense of the impacts of each choice and when to prioritize the new or the old in the context of tension. Whole life sustainability values should also be considered to measure the impacts of change. With this, it is possible to analyze the ethical consequences of accepting the new or maintaining the old, even if the ethics are also under tension (Stoltenberg, 2009).

Ganz-Methode, or the whole approach, encourages the participation of all in the process of tension and its unfolding. Hence, it shows that all human ills and virtues are present in the tension. Therefore, it is important to also expose the tension between the values for life and the values for death in the processes of sense tension.

Moreover, an ethical discussion is a fundamental part of the whole approach to the tension of sense, since the tension is also an ethic. But the ethical discussion in tension models makes it possible to construct parameters for change. With this,

choosing between keeping the old or the new becomes a conscious choice. It is therefore important to analyze the whole impact of tensions in both the local and the global context. This is “today’s new” within exponential tension.

In a further step, the tension between the values for whole life and the values for death are fundamental for the whole tension approach. These values reveal the projects for maintaining the sense of life and also those that are contrary to the sense of life. It is true that the concepts of life and death are also in tension. Therefore, in this whole-tense epistemology, the sense of death is defined as the symbolic and real annihilation of the other. The tension for death is based on the use of power as the domination of the other and of nature itself. This can occur in the local context between people in the same group or by external groups that pressure the local community. The whole approach to creative tension of sense is, ultimately, the option for the generation of life, hope, and sense. This is the power of life. Therefore, the whole approach in movement is also a reflection and exposition of evil in all its dimensions, both theoretical and practical.

7.7 Interconnection Between All Tensions in All Areas of Knowledge and Society: Whole Approach – Ganz-Methode

The university has been the systematizer of knowledge in recent centuries. It also goes through tension like other organizations in society. What is the meaning of the university when this hegemonic knowledge is questioned? The university has been the systematizer of knowledge in recent centuries. It also goes through tension like other organizations in society. What is the meaning of the university when this hegemonic knowledge is questioned? Could it be that the tension of sense is not constitutive today of the university itself? The creative tension of sense within the disciplines has an impact on the choice of content. This choice has an impact on the whole course. The course, in turn, impacts the sense of existing university in relation to the birth of the new within the old and the rapid changes in society. In this respect, the tension between formal knowledge and knowledge in society generates tension in the sense of the university itself. There is, therefore, the tension of sense between the models of new universities that are born within the old universities. The university, in turn, is directly related to the tension between the new society that is born within the old society.

In society there is a sense of tension between global interests and rights in the local community. Further, there is tension between development models that depend on fossil fuels and models that focus on renewable energies. This is a symbol of the tension between two projects of society. At this point, there is the tension of sense between global interests and the rights of the community where the raw material is found. There is also the tension between the use of artificial intelligence and digital technologies and the place that the human being will occupy in the process. This

tension already has an impact on the labor market, causing tension in the human being's reason for existence.

In the local community, the tension between the real and the virtual world creates the tension between interpersonal relationships and life in social networks. In this field, great tensions occur: in the monopoly of information, over the monopoly of participation, in cultural exchanges, identities, and in the concepts of distance, presence, absence, time, space, anguish, solitude, finitude, transcendence, end, and beginning. In the whole approach of Ganz-Methode, this is the context of tension of sense and exponential tension. This is the concept of a *tense society*. Today, all these segments in society are connected by tense relationships in search of sense. This is the concept of whole approach in Ganz-Methode. It is literally the birth of the new world within the old world. This the tension of sense between the “meta” and the “verse”. Living in the real world and in the other reality.

7.8 Conclusion

The central question about the university and higher education is how can they participate in the solution if they are central parts of the problem? One possibility suggested here is to welcome the tension of the birth of the new within the old. As an important locus of the traditional model of the systematization of knowledge, higher education can also assume the epistemology of tension and help the birth of the new. The university can be a “locus” of the life power in society. But for that it needs to be connected to the tension movements in the sense of life in other areas of society. The university also needs affective listening and listening in tension. For this, it will need to horizontalize its relations to capture the life power of all stakeholders. That is why the tension is not outside, but within higher education.

The birth of a new world within an ancient world causes the sense tension of existence, or creative tension of sense. This tension affects all areas of society, and the university. It is necessary to create policies for development of the “new” geopolitics of knowledge in tense contexts. In the epistemology of tension, the whole and distanced approach of the tensions, as shown with the *Ganz-Methode*, is fundamental. This method enables the birth of the new always in the tense support of the old. The protagonism of the new or old will always depend on the community involved in the process, or outsiders who become knowledgeable of the tension despite being outside its context. With this, it is possible to create practical actions and, at the same time, to present the tension between values for whole life and values for death in the process of change and exponential tension. This is the new in tension, or today's new concept. This is the movement that can generate new forms of knowledge in different places of the world in the current environment of rapid and exponential tensions.

Today, the whole education or *Ganz Education* in tension is essential to learn to sustain tensions and to discover the life power of each tense situation and the life power of each person in tension. In the new world, it will be necessary, for example,

to link the choice of work and profession more on the basis of the sense of life and the internal power of life. The power of life is where the values of happiness are built within each person. That's why it's also possible to talk about happiness businesses within the whole of sustainability. It is the individual and collective business in the local community with the technological resources of digital transformation. The three models form the whole business in the era of exponential tension, tense epistemologies, and tense society. This is the wisdom economy in tension theory. In this economy, individuals and organizations develop creative solutions with local knowledge and wisdom to solve individual and collective demands and create conditions for pleasure, health, and happiness.

Actions stemming from tension and the whole approach need to consider the specific tensions of the local context. The same is necessary to address the tensions of external and global contexts on the same issues. The fact is all areas of society experience the tension of sense and they are tightly interconnected. The new situations that arise may be unprecedented in human history. They impact society in a whole way. This new reality causes a tension on the sense of existence of older, more conventional organizations.

The tension of sense and the whole approach in *Ganz-Methode* form the creative tension of sense because they allow the birth of the new world into the old world: tension in concept of the whole life and of existence. However, this birth occurs without excluding one of them in advance. Thus, it would be possible to speak of tense intelligence and whole intelligence to act within the context of rapid changes and exponential tensions. That is the intelligence of "today's new: to educate to sustain tensions and to take whole descriptions. This is a possibility for the epistemologies of higher education to also unite theory and practice with a focus on the power of life: tension of sense and the whole approach as a challenge to the Geopolitics of Knowledge and higher education.

The tensions of sense in different areas of society with the *Ganz-Methode* approach pose some challenges to the "new" geopolitics of knowledge. Which institutions define the types of knowledge with academic validity in the context of exponential tension and of sense of existence? How to recognize with academic criteria the new knowledge that tries to answer the demands by sense in the society? How to analyze this knowledge if the tension of sense also exists within formal and well-established institutions? How to understand this new knowledge if they are inserted into rapid and exponential changes? This implies there is a tension between the time taken to analyze a certain knowledge in traditional institutions and the time in which society is already applying new knowledge to give sense to the questions of whole and tense life. Therefore, it is necessary to sustain the tension between the new and the old.

It is important for a "new" geopolitics of knowledge to open up to the various forms that local communities in various parts of the world have sought to respond to the tension of sense. Many of these forms provoke a sense tension within conventional epistemologies that have been developed in modern societies. In many of these communities, the tension of sense is integrated into the playfulness, the festivals, the rites, the orality, the symbolic, the experience of a whole reality, the

strength of community life, exchanges, art, music, spirituality, and the necessity of explaining rationality to reality as a *sine qua non* of living. Therefore, there is another rationality as the starting point for the interpretation of reality and the organization of life with sense. At this point, there is a challenge for the hegemonic epistemologies of higher education. Welcoming the epistemology of tension and the *Ganz-Methode* can help universities in this transition process.

How is the birth of the new possible without necessarily abandoning the old? The new and old will be subject to the criteria of the sustainability of whole and tense life and the whole impact on the local community. But tension also reveals what is life threatening in this era. This threat is as much from the inside as it can come from the outside. It is tension that can bring life and tension that can bring destruction and death. Increasingly, it is necessary to make a great planetary effort to protect life. It would also be important to think about who the human being is in tension and in her possibilities.

With this, one arrives at the next contribution of tension theory to the methodology of a geopolitics of knowledge: the analysis of knowledge and practice exist together in constant tension. All areas of society feel the tension of sense of existence in the context of rapid and exponential changes. Thus, all tensions are interconnected and change exponentially. This is an exponential tension. The university is not separated from the rest of society. That is why the problem can also be the solution.

What would normality be in a context of the crisis of sense in a tense society? Tension of sense in knowledge, in traditional institutions, because of environmental tension, rapid changes and exponential tensions? Normality in a tense society is the tension of sense. There is a risk that we will have major destructive tensions in the future if tension education does not become a global geopolitical project. This is the era of the new in tension. The tension is normal because the “old” and the “new” must always be together. Therefore, tension is “today’s new”. The theory of tension of sense is the “new” paradigm of knowledge. It can contribute to bringing higher education closer to theory and practice.

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